

Patterns in Play — Module 02: Agents — Think About It

Part A: Family Discussion Questions

1. When you play with a stuffed animal, does it become "real" in your imagination? Why?
2. What is "Pretend Play"? Why is it important for your brain?
3. Can you give your favorite toy a goal? ("Teddy wants to find honey"). How does this feel?
4. What is "Theory of Mind"? (Understanding that other people have their own thoughts and feelings).
5. When you play "Doctor" or "Teacher," what are you practicing? (Being another agent!).
6. How do you decide who plays what role in pretend play?
7. Do video game characters count as agents? (They act, but someone programmed their goals).
8. What happens when two players in a game want different things? How do you work it out?
9. Can you be an agent in someone else's story? (Yes! That is what acting and role-playing is).
10. Why do younger children sometimes think their toys have real feelings?

Part B: Hands-On Activities and Reflection

1. Interview your favorite stuffed animal or toy: What is their name? What do they want? What are they afraid of? Write down the answers. You are practicing theory of mind!
2. Set up a pretend scene with toys or figurines. Give each one a different goal. What happens when their goals overlap?
3. Play "Role Reversal" at home: Kids pretend to be parents, and parents pretend to be kids — for 15 minutes. What did you learn about the other person's experience?
4. Create a "Character Card" for an imaginary friend or toy: Draw them, list their likes, dislikes, and biggest dream.

5. Watch a scene from a movie or show. Pause it and ask: "What is this character thinking right now? What do they want?" Practice reading agents.
6. Play a cooperative board game (where everyone works together). How does teamwork between agents feel different from competition?
7. Tell a round-robin story: One person starts, then each person adds one sentence. Each person is an agent contributing to a shared world.
8. Draw your family as superheroes. Give each person a unique power and a mission. What does each agent bring to the team?
9. Play with action figures or dolls and create a scene where two characters have to solve a problem together. How do they communicate?
10. Before bed, imagine you are the hero of a story. Where are you? What is your quest? What help do you need? Imagining agency builds real-world confidence.